That First Fall

By Daria Polatin

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS 1: *Every year as graduation time rolls around, high school seniors around the country face waves of mixed emotions.*
ACTRESS 2: *Relief that high school is over;*
ACTRESS 1: *Elation to be moving on;*
ACTRESS 2: *And of course, sadness that friends forged over years are going their separate ways.*
ACTRESS 1: *Tearful promises to keep in touch are made, but will things ever truly be the same?*
ACTRESS 2: *For Skyler and Zoe, a Thanksgiving trip home from their 1st year of college forces them to re-examine exactly what they mean to each other.*
TOGETHER: *That First Fall by Daria Polatin*

SKYLER and ZOE, two girls around eighteen, sit on the stoop of a brownstone in Brooklyn. ZOE is dressed in preppy clothes, and SKYLER is a hippy-hipster blend. It's dusk. SKYLER is rummaging through her bag.

SKYLER: I mean it was just like, so lame, you know? Like, we read *Wuthering Heights* in high school, right? And no one there had even heard of it . . . Oh, and also? No one there speaks English. So that's super fun. 'm so over college . . .

ZOE: It'll get better.

SKYLER: I hope so. Do you have to take stupid high school-level English classes too?

ZOE: Kind of. We have these-they call them foundational classes, so there's a lot of remedial stuff.

SKYLER: I don't get it: We already learned that s***, you know? That's *why* we went to high school.

ZOE: I know, but they just want to make sure everyone knows the basics.

SKYLER: I guess. *(After a moment.)* So is your mom making a turkey or is she doing duck again?

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ZOE: We're going to my uncle's in Westchester.

SKYLER: Is your cute cousin gonna be 'there?

ZOE: Dan?

SKYLER: Amanda. *(A tense pause.)*

ZOE: I don't know. My parents haven't really told me much. They're just so excited that I'm home. They won't stop trying to feed me. I've gained, like, two pounds already and I've only been home for a day.

SKYLER: I thought you just got back.

ZOE: Oh, I got in last night.

SKYLER: Why didn't you tell me?

ZOE: It was late; and I had a ton of stuff to do today . . .

SKYLER: I was up last night. You should have told me. I streamed this really crazy ninja movie from this Japanese website with the most amazing subtitles. It was so funny.

ZOE: Cool . . . How's your mom?

SKYLER: She's good. She's selling at a bunch more stores now, so she's busy, which is good.

ZOE: That's great! . . . Have you talked to your dad?

SKYLER: You know, if he did even call? I'd be like, I don't even. wanna talk to you, okay? So don't bother. Hope you're having fun in *Jersey. (Zoe doesn't know what to say.)* He and whatever-her-name-is can take their twins and shove 'em back up her hoo-ha. I was over there last month, and he barely even said a word to me. All he did was fawn over those stupid kids, and he kept being like, "Aren't they cute? Aren't they cute?" Of course, they're cute- they're ***babies***.

ZOE: I'm sorry, Sky.

SKYLER: Oh! Okay, so Friday night, 'member JD? You know, "Rasta-Man"?

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ZOE: JD "The Black White Guy"?

SKYLER: He finally got dreads.

ZOE: Blond dreads? That must look weird.

SKYLER: They actually look kinda cute on him. *(Beat.)* So, okay: He's having everyone over on Friday, and we're gonna, like, party and eat leftover turkey and s***. He's inviting our whole class.

ZOE: Everyone came back?

SKYLER: Pretty much. I think everyone's home, except for Devon -- her family went to, like, Haiti to build houses or something. I think they're Pagan . . . So JD's is gonna be awesome.

ZOE: I'm not sure if I'll be back.

SKYLER: You have to! Everyone's gonna be there. Stella and Todd are back from Vassar, and Evangeline's home from Smith. You're not gonna stay at your uncle's the whole weekend, are you?

ZOE: No . . .

SKYLER: So come back Friday afternoon. Take the train or something.

ZOE: *(Beat.)* On Friday I'm actually going to stay with another friend.

SKYLER: So bring them.

ZOE: In Connecticut.

SKYLER: Who lives in Connecticut?

ZOE: A friend from school.

SKYLER: Oh . . . What's her name?

ZOE: His name is Chandler.

SKYLER: Chandler? Zoe, "Chandler"? Seriously?

ZOE: He's nice.

SKYLER: He must be if your parents are letting you stay with a guy they don't even know.

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ZOE: They do know him.

SKYLER: Your parents met him?

ZOE: A couple of times.

SKYLER: When?

ZOE: At parents' weekend. And . . .

SKYLER: And what, Zoe?

ZOE: . . . He came over for dinner.

SKYLER: You came home? Why didn't you tell me?!

ZOE: It was a really short visit. And I didn't want to bother you 'cause I knew you were busy with schoolwork and stuff.

SKYLER: Um, first of all, if you read any of my emails, Facebook updates, or tweets, or looked at my Instagram, you would know that I happen to be very un-busy with schoolwork. Second of all, this "Chandler" must be a very good friend if you brought him home and you were so busy you didn't even have time to call me.

ZOE: Sky-

SKYLER: So you're gonna, like, go hang out in Connecticut for the weekend at some Ivy League guy's house instead of chilling with your real friends? What are you gonna do, play golf? Cricket?

ZOE: Don't be a snob.

SKYLER: I'm not the one going to Connecticut. Where does he live, Greenwich?

ZOE: Westport. His family is having us over for dinner on Friday, then I'm staying for the weekend.

SKYLER: And your parents are letting you do that? I mean, I know my mom wouldn't care -- she might not even notice if I was gone for a whole weekend, and my dad . . . please. But your parents? Letting you stay at a strange boy's house? This guy must be really special.

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ZOE: Come on, Skyler.

SKYLER: So you're seriously going to hang out with some book-smart, preppy jock rather than hang out with your best friend?

ZOE: . . . It's not like that.

SKYLER: Zoe, we played in Prospect Park before it was safe. We hung out on Fifth Avenue before there were boutiques.

ZOE: I know, it's just . . .

SKYLER: What, Zoe? Now that you go to an Ivy League school and I go to state college, I'm not good enough for you?

ZOE: No.

SKYLER: But, Chandler's your boyfriend, right? Which you didn't even tell me. And you've known him for what, two months? We've known each other since we were born. I can't believe you didn't tell me!

ZOE: I knew you were going to get mad.

SKYLER: I'm mad 'cause you don't tell me anything anymore.

ZOE: I wanted to wait until the right time.

SKYLER: Like, during the two seconds you have to see me before you go back to Connecticut?

ZOE: I'm sorry, Sky.

SKYLER: You know what? Whatever. It's fine. If that's the way you want to be, that's fine.

ZOE: Sky, look, it's not what you think. I still . . . You're still my best friend.

SKYLER: Why thank you, your Yale-ness. *(ZOE gets up.)*

ZOE: I have to get home.

SKYLER: I was kidding. God . . . Don't go . . . *(ZOE takes a moment, then slowly sits back down.)* If you don't want to come to JD's, that's your deal.

ZOE: It's not that I don't want to. I'm just doing something else instead.

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SKYLER: Chandler.

ZOE: Skyler!

SKYLER: What! *(They stare at each other for a few moments. Then, slowly)*

ZOE: . . . What happened in August isn't going to happen again.

SKYLER: What?

ZOE: You know . . . *(Long silence.)* It's not. Going. To happen. Again . . . Ever.

SKYLER: Whatever, we were drunk.

ZOE: I'm not going to do that again . . . I'm not that kind of person.

SKYLER: And what exactly is "that kind of person"? A person like me? You're saying you're not a person like me?

ZOE: No, Sky, it's . . .

SKYLER: What, Zoe, don't they teach you how to speak full sentences at Yale?

ZOE: Stop it. *(SKYLER is quiet. ZOE takes a moment.)* We're friends, Skyler.

SKYLER: I know.

ZOE: That's all.

SKYLER: I get it . , . *(Beat.)* I've been dating a bunch of guys, BTW

ZOE: That's great.

SKYLER: So . . . *(Quiet)* I have to go. My mom's making vegan chili for tomorrow and I have to chop a million vegetables.

ZOE: That sounds good.

SKYLER: It's *vegan chili. (SKYLER gets ready to go. Zoe reaches for her hand.)* What? *(ZOE looks pleadingly at Skyler, her eyes begging her to stay)* Oh . . . Okay. *(SKYLER sits back down)* I do really have to go soon, though.

ZOE: Okay.

SKYLER: Okay . . .

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AWARD HISTORY

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